Most Improved Big State: Punjab

With the onset of winter, Punjab is all set to welcome its huge diaspora that visits friends and families in India in the holiday season. Wedding tourism will be driven by big fat weddings, and religious tourists are expected to queue up at the Golden Temple, the Takht Sri Damdama Sahib, and the Kesgarh Sahib. And for Punjabi Hindu pilgrimage, there are the Durgiana Mandir and the Devi Talab Mandir.

Over the past decade, successive governments in the state have sought to improve religious tourism in Punjab. Chief Minister Bhagwant Mann has taken steps for the enhancement of the *galliara* (corridor) around the Golden Temple, with the installation of a memorial for the Sikh martyr Baba Deep Singh; the government has also improved facilities at the iconic Virasat-e-Khalsa museum at Anandpur Sahib and the theme park at Chamkaur Sahib.

The Punjab government is optimistic about footfalls this year after the Covid-19 slump. Before the pandemic, in 2019, the state hosted 47,385,387 tourists. During Covid curbs, however, the number of domestic tourists dipped to 26,640,429, and foreign tourists to just 308,135.

DRIVEN BY WEDDING AND RELIGIOUS TOURISM, THINGS LOOK UPBEAT FOR PUNJAB THIS YEAR

The state has two international airports in Amritsar and Chandigarh, whereas Pathankot, Adampur, Ludhiana and Bathinda are part of the domestic circuit via the UDAN scheme of the Centre. The state doesn't have natural resources or parks, but is spending over Rs 50 crore on infrastructure to enhance tourism around waterbodies and wetlands.

Most Improved Small State: Delhi

Apart from being the national capital, Delhi is also one of the top tourism destinations in India. In 2019, it was ranked eighth in Euromonitor's list of the world's most visited city of the year. Also the city with the most hotels in the country, Delhi has 173 archaeologically important sites such as the Qutub Minar, Red Fort, Purana Qila, etc. Apart from this, 1,208 heritage structures have been registered as protected in the Delhi Development Authority's 2021 master plan.

In the 2021-22 state budget, two schemes, the Delhi Heritage Promotion and Delhi Tourism Circuit, were launched. The government has also beautified the congested area around the famed Chandni Chowk. Separately, the Delhi Tourism and Transportation Development Corporation maintains other attractions like the Dilli Haat, runs adventure activities and organises food tours, adding to the city's appeal. ■

–Jeemon Jacob, Anilesh S. Mahajan and Manish Dixit

MOST IMPROVED BIG STATES TOURISM

RANK 2022	STATE	SCORE OUT OF 140	RANK 2021
1	PUNJAB	104.0	1
2	UTTARAKHAND	101.2	14
3	KERALA	95.5	3
4	KARNATAKA	89.1	16
5	ANDHRA PRADESH	88.5	2
6	MAHARASHTRA	83.2	11
7	ASSAM	82.5	18
7	UTTAR PRADESH	82.5	4
9	GUJARAT	81.4	8
10	WEST BENGAL	80.5	9
11	RAJASTHAN	77.4	10
12	CHHATTISGARH	76.7	15
13	HARYANA	76.6	19
14	TAMIL NADU	75.2	13
15	TELANGANA	73.0	17
16	BIHAR	65.2	5
17	MADHYA PRADESH	62.1	20
18	ODISHA	53.0	6
19	JHARKHAND	48.6	7
20	HIMACHAL PRADESH	45.7	12

MOST IMPROVED SMALL STATES TOURISM

RANK 2022	STATE	SCORE OUT OF 140	RANK 2021
1	DELHI	91.3	5
2	GOA	89.0	3
3	MANIPUR	78.6	7
4	MIZORAM	76.3	2
5	NAGALAND	70.4	9
6	SIKKIM	68.2	4
7	ARUNACHAL PRADESH	66.0	6
8	PUDUCHERRY	59.2	8
9	MEGHALAYA	57.3	1
10	TRIPURA	45.3	10